

What do Gen Z think about McDonald's food offerings

HEADLINE REFRAME

McDonald's isn't losing Gen Z to competitors, it's losing them to their own unmet expectations. [1, 2, 3]

Obvious. Gen Z eats McDonald's because it's cheap, fast, and everywhere.

Unexpected. Gen Z is actively shaping McDonald's menu through their drink preferences and bold flavour demands, making them a creative force rather than a passive customer base, yet they still show stronger loyalty to rivals like Burger King in some markets.

Interesting. This is really about a generation that holds enormous menu influence but hasn't fully committed, and the gap between what McDonald's is testing and what Gen Z actually feels is theirs to own.

TOPIC BREAKDOWN

Drink-led menu influence. Gen Z's flavour adventurousness is most visible in drinks. McDonald's is directly responding by testing ten new bold drink options, and analysts credit Gen Z with driving new drink innovation across McDonald's and Starbucks alike. [1, 3]

Competitor preference in key markets. Despite McDonald's overall market dominance, Burger King wins Gen Z and Alpha preference in Brazil, pointing to a pattern where the challenger brand reads as more culturally aligned with younger consumers. [2]

Menu anxiety and decision stress. 86% of Gen Z adults aged 18 to 24 report menu anxiety when dining out, compared to 67% of all adults. For a brand with McDonald's scale and complexity, this is a real friction point that affects how welcome and confident Gen Z feel when ordering. [4]

Values-driven food expectations. Gen Z brings strong expectations around health, sustainability, and cost to every food brand interaction. McDonald's sits in tension with several of those values, meaning taste and convenience alone are not enough to secure deep loyalty. [5, 6]

TENSIONS

Gen Z is credited with driving McDonald's menu innovation, yet in at least one major market they prefer a rival. Influence and loyalty are not the same thing, and McDonald's may be listening to Gen Z's taste cues without actually winning their identity. [3, 2]

Gen Z wants bold, experimental food and drink, but also experiences more menu anxiety than any other generation. The demand for novelty and the stress of choosing from a vast menu pull in opposite directions, and McDonald's expanding range could make both feelings worse at once. [1, 4]

Gen Z holds strong sustainability and health values, yet fast food remains a regular part of how they eat out. The rationalisation between those values and the McDonald's visit is something the generation is quietly managing, not resolving. [5, 6]

CONSUMER VOICE

Gen Z frames menu confidence as a generational identity marker, positioning themselves as decisive and waste-free compared to older cohorts. [4]

"Millennials would say: we've refreshed the menu. Gen Z: we ate and left no crumbs."

Despite that confident framing, the data tells a different story: Gen Z is the generation most likely to feel stressed by too many choices on a menu. [4]

"About 86% of Gen Z adults aged 18 to 24 reported experiencing menu anxiety when dining in

restaurants, compared to 67% of all adults."

SUGGESTED CREATOR ANGLES

The honest order: a creator builds a series around cutting through menu overwhelm at McDonald's, showing exactly what to get and why, no fluff.. Menu anxiety is measurably higher in Gen Z than any other group. A creator who positions themselves as a trusted guide rather than a hype machine addresses a real emotional need while keeping McDonald's at the centre of the content. [4]

Drinks lab: a creator tests and ranks the new bold drink range, treating McDonald's like a craft beverage destination rather than a default stop.. Gen Z's influence on McDonald's drink innovation is already documented. Leaning into that creative ownership, rather than generic fast food content, repositions the brand as a place where Gen Z taste actually matters. [1, 3]

Values check: a creator openly interrogates how McDonald's fits or doesn't fit into a Gen Z lifestyle that cares about health and sustainability, without pretending the tension doesn't exist.. Gen Z is sceptical of brands that ignore contradictions. A creator who names the tension honestly builds more trust than one who papers over it, and that trust transfers to the brand if McDonald's is willing to be part of the conversation. [5, 6]

VERIFIED SOURCES

[1] McDonald's tests 10 new bold drinks for Gen Z (web / expert / verified)

<https://www.facebook.com/CBSNews/posts/mcdonalds-plans-to-test-10-new-drinks-in-hundreds-of-us-stores-as-the-restaurant/11491193>

[2] McDonald's Leads in Brazil; Burger King Wins Gen Z & Alpha (web / expert / verified)

<https://www.kantar.com/inspiration/fmcg/mcdonalds-leads-in-brazil-burger-king-wins-gen-z-and-alpha>

[3] You can thank Gen Z for new drink options from McDonald's, Starbucks (web / expert / verified)

<https://www.yahoo.com/lifestyle/articles/thank-gen-z-drink-options-070902699.html>

[4] Millennials would say: "we've refreshed the menu ... (web / consumer / verified)

<https://www.facebook.com/thecoffeeclubnz/posts/millennials-would-say-weve-refreshed-the-menu-%EF%B8%8Fgen-z-we-ate-and-left-no>

[5] BIG little LDN | What Gen Z Want From Food Brands in 2024 (web / expert / verified)

https://cdn.prod.website-files.com/62d670dcfc5ed45dd46f6bef/65df37fc2105378880e96fe8_What%20Gen%20Z%20Want%20From%20F

[6] How Gen Z eats out: Top restaurants, dining habits, and food values (web / expert / verified)

<https://yougov.com/en-us/articles/52792-how-gen-z-eats-out-top-restaurants-dining-habits-and-food-values>